

Teaching Manual: Oral Problem-Solving Interview

Scripted lesson | 60-75 minutes

LESSON OVERVIEW

Learning goal: Assess reasoning, flexibility, mathematical language, and response to unfamiliar problems.

Success Criteria

- The student represents the idea with a model, drawing, table, or number line.
- The student uses the lesson vocabulary accurately.
- The student explains why a strategy works and checks reasonableness.
- The student can respond independently to: Tell the student one specific mathematical habit that has grown.

Teaching Theory

Cumulative review strengthens retrieval and connections across topics. Corrections are most useful when students identify the cause of an error, rebuild the idea, and solve a transfer problem.

Instructional principle: Move concrete -> pictorial -> abstract. Do not remove the model until the student can explain the symbolic work.

Lesson Flow

5-8 min	Number talk
10 min	Vocabulary and worked example
20 min	Main lesson
15 min	Practice
10 min	Challenge
5 min	Exit check

Materials: Preparation and Use

BEFORE THE STUDENT ARRIVES

Counters	Sort into labeled piles. Use first to build the quantity, then keep the model visible while recording symbols.
grid paper	Place beside the student. Use for drawings, organized records, and a second representation.
fraction strips	Sort into labeled piles. Use first to build the quantity, then keep the model visible while recording symbols.
interview notes.	Prepare before the lesson and introduce it only when it supports the current mathematical idea.

Table Setup

- Center: the main model or tool for today's lesson.
- Student side: packet, pencil, and only the materials currently needed.
- Teacher side: answer notes and observation record, kept out of student view.
- Leave a clear space where the student can point, move pieces, and explain.

Vocabulary to Establish

strategy: Ask the student for an example or picture before refining the definition.

evidence: Ask the student for an example or picture before refining the definition.

revise: Ask the student for an example or picture before refining the definition.

transfer: Ask the student for an example or picture before refining the definition.

accurate: Ask the student for an example or picture before refining the definition.

efficient: Ask the student for an example or picture before refining the definition.

Material rule: The student should touch, draw, measure, or organize the mathematics before copying a procedure.

Phase 1: Launch and Number Talk

EXACT TEACHER LANGUAGE

Teacher says	"Today we are learning to assess reasoning, flexibility, mathematical language, and response to unfamiliar problems. Before I show a method, I want to hear how you see the numbers."
Why	Positions the student as a mathematical thinker and makes prior knowledge visible.
Listen for	Useful representations, precise vocabulary, and whether the student checks reasonableness.
Then do	Acknowledge the idea neutrally, then ask for evidence rather than immediately evaluating it.

Number Talk Prompt

Teacher says	"What do you notice?"
Why	Surfaces the relationships needed in the main lesson.
Listen for	Any reasoning connected to review and reflection, not only a final answer.
Then do	Ask: 'Can you show that another way?' Record two distinct strategies when possible.

Prompt Ladder

First: What do you notice? What could you try?
Next: Can you draw, build, or organize the information?
Then: Which part of today's vocabulary fits your idea?
Last resort: Solve a smaller related case, then return to the original.

Phase 2: Explicit Teaching

MODEL, QUESTION, CONNECT

Teaching Step 1

Teacher says	"Let us solve 8×7 in two ways. Tell me what I should do first and why."
Why	Keeps the student cognitively active during explicit instruction.
Listen for	A connection between the representation and the mathematical symbols.
Then do	Model only the next move. Pause and return responsibility to the student.

Teaching Step 2

Teacher says	"Let us explain $902 - 476$. Tell me what I should do first and why."
Why	Keeps the student cognitively active during explicit instruction.
Listen for	A connection between the representation and the mathematical symbols.
Then do	Model only the next move. Pause and return responsibility to the student.

Teaching Step 3

Teacher says	"Let us compare $\frac{2}{3}$ and $\frac{2}{5}$. Tell me what I should do first and why."
Why	Keeps the student cognitively active during explicit instruction.
Listen for	A connection between the representation and the mathematical symbols.
Then do	Model only the next move. Pause and return responsibility to the student.

Teaching Step 4

Teacher says	"Let us draw two rectangles with area 24. Tell me what I should do first and why."
Why	Keeps the student cognitively active during explicit instruction.
Listen for	A connection between the representation and the mathematical symbols.
Then do	Model only the next move. Pause and return responsibility to the student.

Teaching Step 5

Teacher says	"Let us solve a two-step story. Tell me what I should do first and why."
Why	Keeps the student cognitively active during explicit instruction.
Listen for	A connection between the representation and the mathematical symbols.
Then do	Model only the next move. Pause and return responsibility to the student.

Teaching Step 6

Teacher says	"Let us attempt one unfamiliar logic or counting problem. Tell me what I should do first and why."
Why	Keeps the student cognitively active during explicit instruction.
Listen for	A connection between the representation and the mathematical symbols.
Then do	Model only the next move. Pause and return responsibility to the student.

Representation check: Before leaving the model, ask the student to point to every part of the matching equation or statement.

Phase 3: Guided and Independent Practice

RELEASE RESPONSIBILITY GRADUALLY

I Do -> We Do -> You Do

- I do: complete the packet's worked example while narrating the reason for each move.
- We do: solve the first practice task together; the student chooses the representation.
- You do: the student completes the remaining tasks while explaining selected answers.

Teacher says	"Practice task 1: Why does that work? Before solving, tell me what the task is asking and which tool might help."
Listen for	Correct interpretation before computation.
Then do	Use the prompt ladder. Avoid completing a step the student can perform.

Teacher says	"Practice task 2: Can you show another representation? Before solving, tell me what the task is asking and which tool might help."
Listen for	Correct interpretation before computation.
Then do	Use the prompt ladder. Avoid completing a step the student can perform.

Teacher says	"Practice task 3: How could you check? Before solving, tell me what the task is asking and which tool might help."
Listen for	Correct interpretation before computation.
Then do	Use the prompt ladder. Avoid completing a step the student can perform.

Teacher says	"Practice task 4: What would happen if the numbers changed? Before solving, tell me what the task is asking and which tool might help."
Listen for	Correct interpretation before computation.
Then do	Use the prompt ladder. Avoid completing a step the student can perform.

Common Misconceptions

Watch for: Treating a score as more important than error analysis.

Watch for: Copying a correction without explaining the changed idea.

Watch for: Choosing a strategy from habit rather than problem structure.

Differentiation

Secure: Remove routine repetition and ask for a second method, proof, or generalization.

Developing: Keep the visual model visible and reduce the number size while preserving the same structure.

Fragile: Return to a concrete example, use one question at a time, and delay independent symbols.

Phase 4: Challenge, Assessment, and Feedback

PROTECT PRODUCTIVE STRUGGLE

Teacher says	"Challenge: Create a related problem and explain its solution. You may draw, make a table, test a simpler case, or work backward. I will give you thinking time before offering a hint."
Why	Builds persistence and strategy selection rather than rapid answer production.
Listen for	An organized plan, revision after a failed attempt, and a justification.
Then do	Praise a specific mathematical action: organization, checking, representation, or explanation.

Exit Check

Teacher says	"Complete this independently: Tell the student one specific mathematical habit that has grown."
Why	Provides evidence of the central lesson goal without teacher prompting.
Then do	After completion, ask one clarifying question only if the written reasoning is ambiguous.

Evidence Guide

Secure	Correct and independently justified	Proceed; add a variation or ask the student to teach the idea.
Developing	Correct with model or prompt	Proceed with the model available and begin next lesson with retrieval.
Fragile	Incorrect structure or unexplained answer	Reteach with smaller quantities and a concrete representation.

Answer and Observation Guide

USE AFTER INDEPENDENT WORK

Expected Mathematical Evidence

- Number talk: a defensible response to 'What do you notice?' with a model or explanation.
- Main lesson: evidence that the student can assess reasoning, flexibility, mathematical language, and response to unfamiliar problems.
- Practice: accurate work with units, labels, and a reasonableness check where appropriate.
- Challenge: an organized attempt at 'Create a related problem and explain its solution.' and an explanation of the chosen strategy.
- Exit: an independent response to 'Tell the student one specific mathematical habit that has grown.'

Teacher Verification Routine

- Rework every numerical answer before marking it.
- Accept a different method when the reasoning is valid.
- For open problems, verify that every condition is satisfied.
- For measurement, data, and geometry, require correct units and labels.
- For explanations, distinguish a correct statement from a demonstrated reason.

Observation Record

A strong strategy the student used:

A misconception to revisit:

Vocabulary used precisely:

Material or representation that helped:

Plan for the next lesson:
